Ocean's Shores'. They are testimony to the great wealth and cosmopolitan character of these great cities. Then, as described in these earlier chapters, the Ming emperor forbade further maritime expeditions and China descended into studied insularity, which continued under the ensuing Qing dynasty under the Manchus.

The Qing harboured inherited notions of India as a land of Buddhism lying to the west, but could not reconcile this with reports about a Mughal empire then ruling that geography. So the geography itself was adjusted to locate India to the south of what was now the Mughal empire. The fall of the Mughals in the mid-eighteenth century and the emergence of British colonial rule in India, with all its implications for China, was for several decades only vaguely understood. This is covered in fascinating detail by Matthew Mosca in his landmark book, *From Frontier Policy to Foreign Policy: The Question of India and the Transformation of Geopolitics in Qing China* . It was with the Opium Wars of 1839–42 and 1856–60 that China was deeply shaken by its vulnerability to a British empire now firmly established in the Asian continent, which drew its power and resources from its colonial empire in India.

The opium which drained China of silver and enfeebled its citizens, and the Indian soldiers who served as the shock troops during the humiliating Opium Wars, led the Qing court and Chinese intellectuals to examine the reasons behind Chinese weakness. Associated with this was an exploration of the Indian condition and India's role as a springboard for the painful British assault on China. Consequently, there emerged, in parallel, a deeply negative popular perception of Indians from their role as street-side enforcers of British rule in the foreign concessions. There was also deep resentment of the prominent Indian traders in cities like Shanghai who flaunted their wealth, gained mainly from the opium trade.

Chinese intellectuals, whether conservative reformers like Kang Youwei and Liang Qichao, whom we encountered in the previous chapter, or more radical figures like Chen Duxiu, Lu Xun or Liang Shuming, saw India as a 'worst-case scenario' for China. India's past as a brilliant and sophisticated civilization was acknowledged, but its more recent history was of special